I May Have Broke Three Rules

There are three rules of the court:

1. Don't touch the threads unless you're told to.

2. Don't speak your true name aloud.

3. And no circumstance should you make eye contact to the Fallen Spinner currently watching you across the Sartyx with the intensity of a curse.

I've broken all three.
Technically, the first one was an accident. The second one... I was thirteen and thought I was clever. The third? That one is happening right now, and I hate how much I can't look away.

He still has the same eyes—gilded and radiant.
And the same mouth that speaks in silk and cuts like shears.

"You look like a sin," He says, tilting his head.

"You still talk like a bad poem." I mutter, smoothed down my own skirt.

The silk gloves on my hands are enchanted. Not to protect me, no. To protect them. Because if I touch a thread of fate with bare fingers, it frays. Unravels. Screams.

I should leave. I should go back to my little attic room and the quiet hum of old spools and whispering fabric. But something in his look tells me tonight is not just silk and song.

It’s blood.

It’s memory.

It’s him.

And I—I don’t want to forgive him.

Phoibus, son of Cealustus. He was known as the "Spinner of All Threads". Everyone in Fatum knows his name—third son of the King of Clothos and the only one who holds the power of *Preastes*.

He and I had... history. A really long one. Pretty tragic if you ask me. It involves alot of broken threads and discarded fabrics.

“Reminiscing?” he asks, his voice low with a strange, unrecognizable lilt.

He adjusts his cuffs with his usual confidence, then sends me a look—a gentle one.

"... There is nothing worth remembering."

He hums softly. The rustle and whisper of threads fill the silence between us. His hands, delicate and deliberate, weave new strands into the fabric. The tension in the room thickens with every motion.

“May I ask,” he continues, his eyes never leaving the threads, “Why, Daphni of Iluyto, are you visiting the Sartyx?”

When you yourself declared, years ago, that you would never set foot in it again?”

He weaves a final thread, his tone shifting—more pointed. More knowing.

I drew in a shaky breath. The fabric of my gloves muffled the warmth rising in my palms—heat threatening to bloom, to betray me.

“I’ve been sent here,” I said quietly, “to become your apprentice.”

Then I dipped into a curtsy—measured, precise.

The kind reserved only for those who bear a royal crest.

His loom stops.

Just… stops.

I don't dare raise my head. When a Spinster—especially one with royal blood—suddenly halts their loom, it only means one thing.

Something serious has happened.

And that "something" is currently in a curtsy and sweating through her gloves.

Imagine this:

Your former apprentice, who loudly declared before an entire court that she would never, ever step foot in the City of Fatum again… walks back into your domain and says,

"Yeah, about that. Take me back. Please."

Yeah.

Seriously though, can he respond already?

Maintaining a curtsy is starting to feel like slow torture.

A chair creaks behind the loom. Measured footsteps follow. A pair of shoes stopped just in front of mine.

"Rise."

I lift my head—and meet his eyes.

Golden. Bright. So very unreadable.

“Daphni of Iluyto,” he says softly. “Why did you choose to work with the one they call the Fallen Spinner?”

“I didn’t choose—”

I stopped—just before his gaze could harden.

Cleared my throat. Straightened my spine.

“Fallen Spinner or not, you still hold the power of Preastres.”

I pause. Let the weight of it settle. Let him wonder how much of that was praise—and how much was reminder.

“And as the one who will soon rule Clothos… well, anyone would accept an apprenticeship under that.”

Phoibus chuckles. Amused? Probably.

I was always good with words.

“Is that so?” His smile never wavers, dimples deepening like wells you shouldn’t fall into.

“And oh, dear Daphni—why must I accept you as mine if you already rebuked it back then?”

That was past me. Not me-me. This is me. Now.

I keep my spine straight, keep the gloves from twitching.

“That was then,” I say. “And this is now.”

Phoibus walks back to the loom with reverence and grace—

the kind only a royal prince could master.

I wished he'd trip.

He didn't.

Of course he didn't.

He settles into his chair with practiced ease and begins to weave, fingers precise and unforgiving.

"Then as an experienced apprentice," he says, "you already know how the Third Prince of Clothos tests his?"

He hooks a new thread, guiding it through the reed with elegant detachment.

"Grab me a thread, Iluytri."

Ah. There he is.

The annoying, pesky, sharp-tongued Yarn Brain.

I might've stood still a little too long—because just as I finally moved to calmly retrieve a thread, I heard that voice again, smooth and screechy all at once:

"Can't?"

The flames nearly erupted in my palms.

"If His Royal Highness could… perhaps practice silence while I attempt my test—"

"Ah-ah."

He doesn't even look up.

"Apprentices should learn to hold their tongues and follow orders."

If we weren’t surrounded by sacred threads, I would’ve singed his eyebrows off until there wasn’t a single golden hair left.

Being an Apprentice To Self Control

As an experienced apprentice to the Third Prince of Clothos, you'd think I completed the test swiftly.

I did not.

Now, before you say: But Daphni, you and Phoibus have history—surely the test was easy peasy?

Sure. If you consider emotional warfare under royal surveillance easy peasy.

Phoibus was never unkind. Nor was he cruel.

But he carried this annoyingly prudent sense of judgment—especially when it came to trials. Just like before.

Our story may have ended abysmally, but even I can admit one thing: Phoibus treats his work—and his candidacy for the crown—with unwavering seriousness.

And when Phoibus is serious about something, he doesn't simply focus. He organizes fate around it. He becomes besotted. Driven. Obsessed with keeping things in order—even if it means breaking what doesn't fit.

The trials were simple. "Even the children of Clothos can do this in under three minutes," he said, dimples deepening and eyes crinkling like he was trying not to laugh.

Annoying. I know.

The task? Straightforward.

1. Grab three threads.

2. Weave them into a plain.

That was it. That was the trial.

The thing is—I'm not a child of Clothos.

I hail from Iluyto. And do you know what Iluyto is known for?

Cooks. Those who weave the power of warmth so potent, the threads burn at a touch.

The Sartyx rarely welcomes Iluytris as Spinners.

They're usually redirected—turned into housemaids, cooks (the literal kind), and quiet little assistants.

Never a Spinster.

When I finally stepped forward—slow, deliberate—the sound of the Loom stopped.

Just like that. Silence.

I flinched as the thrum of the threads rippled through the air, straight into my bones. They were alive. Listening. Waiting.

Three. Just three.

Warmth began to seep in.

But I held it. Inhaled. Swallowed. Contained. This wasn't just a test of skill. It was a test of memory. Of place. Of whether I still belonged in a place that once shattered me.

When I turned back to the loom, Phoibus was already standing— his golden eyes locked on my hands.

The hands holding three threads. Three fates. Each one heavier than they looked.

“Good.” He adjusts the loom, gestures toward the seat. “Come and weave.”

I sit. Slowly.

His warmth lingers in the chair.

And I hate that I notice it.

“Don’t tell me you’ve forgotten how to weave?” A bothersome voice quips beside me. “Do you need me to hold your hand and guide you through it?”

Warmth spikes—nearly escapes.

The Prince is testing my temper. (Note: do not test the temper of an Iluytri. Especially in the Sartyx. Just a warning.)

“Your Royal Highness,” I say, tightly, “with all due respect… I think you’re trying to sabotage my test.” I feel my eyebrow twitch as I gently—gently—fasten the warp onto the loom. “Also, could you move a little? I can feel your breath on my skin and it’s a little… annoying.”

He laughs.

Annoying.

I press on—preparing the weft yarn, sliding the shed stick into the warp threads. Doing this with gloves is incredibly irritating, but I can’t discard them. Not unless I want to accidentally ignite the three threads of fate I’m holding together by sheer spite and muscle memory.

I start to weave a plain.

“You’ve improved.” I feel him shift beside me. Closer. Lower. He’s kneeling now.

His presence hovers—his voice quiet. Measured.

“You’re not saying my name anymore.”

I continue weaving. Silently. Carefully.

"You used to weave and look at me.” “‘Is this okay, Phoibus?’” “‘Phoibus, I can feel warmth! I think I should stop!’” His voice lifts into a squeaky, dramatic lilt—a terrible imitation.

“Now, you just furrow your eyebrows. What did the poor weave ever do to you?”

“I would appreciate,” I say, sharp and flat, “if the Prince refrained from opening old wounds.”

The warmth pulses. In and out. In and out. Like it can hear him too.

“Ah,” he hums, not missing a beat. “But this is part of the test.”

“What part?”

"Testing your patience.”

He rests his chin on his knees.

“And you’re slowly failing.”

The gloves tighten. Start to glow. I let go of the loom. Fingers trembling.

Control. Contain. Inhale. Swallow.

I glare at him.

He smiles back.

“I see you’ve learned to control your warmth.” His gaze lowers to my hands. He hovers near them—close enough to notice the tremble, never close enough to touch. “New gloves?”

“I think it would be wise if we stop with the small talk,” I mutter, continuing to weave.

He’s silent for a while.

“Ah, but apprentices and their masters should at least have some sort of relationship, no?” He hums the words like a tune he’s half-forgotten.

I say nothing. Weave. Thread. Weave.

But—

Because I have a conscience.
Because I’m not as cold as I pretend to be.

“…Lionel’s.”

“Hm?”
His head snaps toward me. Eyes wide. Hopeful.

“The gloves,” I say, still focused on the loom. “Got them at Lionel’s.”

Silence. Not long. Just enough for a memory to try creeping in.

I don’t let it.

“Still puts the fire-thread silks by the window,” I add, like it’s nothing. Like it doesn’t mean anything. “Easy to find.”

His dimples twitch—small, unreadable.

“He always did have a sense of drama.”

“Makes it easier to shop,” I mutter, adjusting the tension. “Nothing else.”

I don’t mention the back room where we used to argue about color palettes. Or the time he stitched goldthread into the hem of my coat while Phoibus lectured him about imbalance.

I don’t mention anything.

And he—thankfully—doesn’t push.

So I keep weaving.

Under my fingers, the threads align.
Over. Under. Over. Under.
Like breath. Like control. Like every thought I don’t say aloud.

The plain begins to take shape—clean, unburnt, and stable.

I adjust the shed stick. Tighten the tension. Inhale. Count.

And then, just like that, it’s done.

Simple. Neat. Unremarkable.

Which, in the Sartyx, is the highest praise an Iluytri can hope for.

I turn. Offer the cloth with both hands.

Phoibus takes it like it’s spun glass.
Delicate. Careful. Almost reverent.

“A magnificent plain,” he says softly.
“You pass.”

I smile.

Warm. Real. Stupid.

Then I remember myself.

“…Daphni of Iluyto. My second-aide.”

Ah.

Victory

Yarn Brain's Apprentice, Officially (AGAIN)

The title’s mine. Not theirs.

Next stop? The admissions office in the Sartyx.

Yes, there are processes—long, tedious, and glittered in bureaucracy. Clothos breeds order the way Iluyto breeds warmth. So naturally, the Sartyx, being the kingdom’s most sacred weaving hall, runs on exact lines and exhausting amounts of paperwork.

I follow Phoibus through corridors that gleam with opulence.
The walls are trimmed in gold. The floors are white marble. The ceilings glitter with inlaid starlight.

Little Kaabaigs flit above our heads—scrolls in their arms so enormous they look like they’re about to tip sideways mid-flight. They chatter in high-pitched hums, skimming documents and bumping into chandeliers. The entire place buzzes like an over-glorified hive of thread-obsessed bees.

Sunlight filters in through the glass roof, turning the already shimmering hallways into a glowing cathedral of gold.

Seriously.
What is it with this place and gold?
A little silver wouldn’t kill them. A dash of copper? Something?

We round a bend and enter the heart of the Sartyx.

The Oraisayn stands in the center.
An hourglass—taller than Phoibus, made of enchanted glass and weeping marble.
The sand inside glows cerulean, drifting downward with an unnatural slowness.

They say when the Oraisayn runs out, the entire structure resets—

All threads will unspool.
All fate will be rewritten.

Comforting, right?

Phoibus stops beside it. The light catches in his eyes, sharp and soft all at once.

He turns to me, and with a voice far too calm, says:

“Now comes the trial of registry.”

I blink. “...I just wove a perfect plain.”

“Which proves your hands.” He shrugs. “But not your intent.”

Oh. Good. More hoops.

Behind the registrar's cubicle sat a Talus—better known as “The Ones Who Write.”

Her expression balanced delicately between “Oh no, not more paperwork” and “Hello ma’am/sir, how may I ruin your life politely today?”

To be fair, if I were in her place, I’d wear the same expression.

Especially with the mountain of documents behind her, stacked so high they nearly obscured the intricate weaving patterns on the marble wall. It loomed over her like an avalanche waiting for a sigh too loud.

Reasonable.

She glanced up at Phoibus. Her expression changed immediately.
Not out of respect. No.
But because royalty means expedited forms.

“Third Prince,” she said with an impeccable bow of the head.

Then her gaze slid to me—calculating, curious, unimpressed.
An Iluytri in the Sartyx?
She might as well have stamped ‘anomaly’ on my forehead.

Phoibus stepped forward, voice smooth as royal thread.

“This is Daphni of Iluyto. She’s to be registered as my second-aide.”
“Apprentice,” he added, casually—like it didn’t mean setting the building on fire in gossip.

The Talus didn’t blink. Just pulled a scroll from her desk, dipped a quill into glowing ink, and muttered,

“Name. Birthmark of thread. Finger imprint. Any minor burns I should be aware of?”

Reasonable. Again.

I cleared my throat.
Y’know, just in case my vocal cords decided to betray me and croak like an Iluytri toad.
My reputation is already as low as the city’s sewers—no need to add “sounds like a frog” to the list.

“Daphni.”

“Uh-huh. Daughter of who?”
The Talus didn’t even look up. Her quill scratched against the scroll with mechanical precision, her pink hair bouncing—more like flailing—with every stroke.

“Daughter of nobody, miss.”

The scratching stopped.

Just for a beat.
A moment.
A silence that hung between ink and truth.

Then she resumed writing.

As if that answered everything.

As if it was enough.

“Okay,” the Talus murmured.
Her voice had lost its clipped efficiency—softened, suddenly unsure.
“Any previous records here in the Sartyx?”

Oh no.

“Uh… yes.”
And not a good one, either. But hey—let bygones be bygones! New gloves, new life, right?

Phoibus shifted behind me.
I didn’t have to look to know he was doing that thing—
Tight smile. Relaxed stance. Dangerous intent.

“What she meant to say,” he cut in smoothly, “was no.”

Silence.

My head snapped toward him.

My eyes screamed: Sir. That is a Talus. A court-recorded, fate-transcribing, paper-hoarding Talus. And you are LYING?

He met my look. Blinked. Smiled wider.

As if to say:
Let them record what I allow.

The Talus finally raised her head, and I caught her name etched in delicate gold on her lapel:
'Laytana.'

She blinked once at Phoibus, unimpressed.
Then her perfectly sculpted eyebrow rose—sharp and judgmental.
Her green eyes narrowed, cutting through Phoibus like they were forged to do just that.

He, of course, smiled wider.
His eyes crinkled at the edges like he was holding back laughter—or a secret he'd never let go.

"Your Highness—" she began, all sharp professionalism.

"Laytana," he interrupted, smooth as a spool of silk.
"If you must, I can testify for Ms. Daphni's records."

Laytana turned to me.
And oh gods.
The look.

Brows furrowed. Nose wrinkled. Mouth set in that "ma'am I don't get paid enough for this" way.

Please don't look at me like that, I begged silently.
I was honest!

Laytana just sighed and scribbled something onto the scroll.

Reasonable.
Fallen Spinner or not, Phoibus was still a prince.
The future King of Clothos.
His word wasn't just law—it rewrote it.

She gestured toward me with a flick of her quill.

"Gloves off."

I hesitated.

Just for a moment.
Then I took a breath and slipped the periwinkle gloves from my fingers—
carefully. Precisely.

Warmth surged.
It started in my palms.
Then bloomed outward—fiery, radiant, untamed.

The air shimmered.

Laytana shrieked.
Actually shrieked.
Clutched her scroll like it could shield her from spontaneous combustion.

"By the Threads, what—"

"I'm an Iluytri," I said flatly, wriggling my fingers to shake off the glow. "This is kind of normal."

Laytana blinked.
Twice.

Phoibus, behind me, made a noise that I refused to interpret as laughter.

“Your Highness, are you sure it is wise—”

“I trust Ms. Daphni’s capabilities,” Phoibus said, cutting in without even looking at Laytana.

Poor Laytana.
Third interruption in under five minutes.

She took a deep, patient breath that sounded like it came from the bottom of her spine, and pushed a document across the marble desk.

“...Okay. Please stamp this document with your fingerprint, Ms.”

The gold nectar shimmered in its little glass dish—thick, warm, and humming with soft magical resonance.

I pressed my thumb into it.
Tamped down the rising heat.
Held my breath.

Then stamped.

A perfect golden print.
Unburned. Just barely.

Laytana examined it, nodded, and pulled out another scroll.

“Birthmark of thread?”

I hesitated.

This part was always the worst.

Not because I didn't know it.
But because I did.

Phoibus stilled behind me.

I lifted my chin.

"Renovamen," I said quietly.

A hush fell between us.

The Kaabaigs above flitted slower.
The Oraisayn, I swear, ticked louder.

Laytana looked up at me. For the first time, really looked.

And in her eyes—no pity.

Only recognition.

"Ah. So you're that one."
Laytana muttered it just under her breath—enough for me to hear, enough for Phoibus to pretend he didn't.

She gave a low whistle and waved over a Kaabaig, who fluttered in with wide, panicked eyes.
The moment she passed the registration scroll, the poor thing nearly dropped out of the air—drowning in paperwork.

"Not my business," Laytana said, casually ignoring the Kaabaig spiraling like a lost napkin in a breeze.
"Congratulations on being the Third Prince's Apprentice."

Then, without a change in expression—without joy, excitement, or even basic alertness—she ducked under the desk…

…and pulled out a small brass hatch.
From it: confetti.

Of course.

Without a word, she tossed a handful into the air.
No smile. No enthusiasm.
Just solemn obligation and perfectly practiced grace.

The confetti fluttered downward like sad starlight.
Phoibus blinked.
I blinked.

“...Do you have to do that for everyone?” I asked cautiously.

“Protocol,” Laytana said. Completely serious.

10/10. No notes.
Give this woman a raise. Or a nap. Maybe both.

Phoibus Just Hanged A Kaabaig

After the registration incident, Phoibus lead me to my room. Which I later realized that the pathways we took were all familiar.

The same portraits—mostly of those who wielded Preastres.
The same uneven tiles that always made my eye twitch.
The same bush of periwinkle flowers I used to over pluck for flower crowns.

Good times.

When I came to be, we stopped at a familiar door. I spot the faint scorch mark near the handle.

"This room?" I turned to him, his eyes never left the doorknob.

He nods once, slow and deliberate. “I had it left untouched.”

A pause. Memory settles like dust between us—too heavy to sweep. Too polite to name.

“I thought they would have reassigned it,” I say, forcing a lightness I don’t feel. “Or, I don’t know… burned it down, considering the incident.”

Phoibus’s lips twitch—not quite a smile. “They considered it. But then again, Clothos values restoration.”

“And yet you’re called the Fallen Spinner,” I mutter, reaching for the handle. It’s warm. Still.

“So are you,” he says simply, like a fact. Like a shared scar.

The room was... dusty.

The bookcase—where I used to stack my shopping hauls under the guise of “literary taste”—was untouched. Still organized the way I left it: classics on the top shelf, fiction on the bottom.

My desk, once buried in journals and notebooks, had been meticulously cleaned—just as I used to do it. Journals to the left. Notebooks to the right. Pencils centered, aligned like soldiers.

And on the corkboard?

My sketches.

Still there. Still pinned with those little flower clips I adored.

My bed?

Still there—carved into the headboard was a golden insignia: the mark of Preastres.

A shield, lined with sunrays.

My eyes drifted to the only person in the entire generation who could wield it.

The only one who ever could.

"Did you seriously cast Preastres on the bed?"

Phoibus shrugged, voice maddeningly nonchalant.

"How could I not? I wove those sheets."
A pause. Then, almost like an afterthought—
"Only ones I ever did."

Let's stop right there. No need to open already opened cans!

Phoibus whistles.

A soft poof of dandelion smoke bursts in the air—
and from it, a Kaabaig materializes.

He's tiny, barely the length of my forearm, with chopped black hair and skin pale as snow. His leafy cloak flutters as he stomps—

Yes. On air.

"Your Highness!" he snaps, his voice a flurry of wind chimes and outrage.
"I told you not to summon me while I'm tending the vines!"

Phoibus flicks the poor thing's hat off.

The Kaabaig lets out a screech—something between a gasp and an Kaian curse—
and dives after it like his dignity depends on it.

His arms flail. His bells jingle in fury.
If he gets any redder, I fear he might spontaneously combust.

"Minnie Dimitri," Phoibus bows—low, reverent.

That immediately shuts the little guy up.

The Kaabaig freezes mid-air. His wings stutter.

"I see you haven't outgrown your tantrums," Phoibus muses, smiling just enough to be dangerous.
"Should I remind you what happened last time you earned detention?"

That does it.

Dimitri's wings droop. His rage wilts like a scorched fern.
He pulls his cloak around himself with the solemn grace of someone who has, in fact, been to detention before and does not wish to return.

"…What does Your Highness need?"
Dimitri's clipped, sulky tone made me want to laugh out loud.
But I remembered he was currently being scolded, so I kept a straight face.

My muscles were being held together by sheer will. And maybe my teeth.

"Do you remember what I said?" Phoibus said calmly. "That you'd be assigned to a new trainee?"
He gestures toward me.

"Well. Here she is.
Meet Daphni of Iluyto.
My second-aide."

Dimitri stares.

At Phoibus.
At me.
Back at Phoibus.
Like the Prince had just grown a second head made of thorns and bad decisions.

Then the Kaabaig tries to poof out of existence.

Phoibus snatches him out of mid-air with two fingers.

"Where do you think you're going?"

Minnie Dimitri flails, fluttering wildly in Phoibus' grip—trying to climb higher and higher like a moth fleeing an open flame.

Which is objectively a terrible escape strategy, considering the Prince is built like a very well-dressed siege tower.

"NO—NO—" Dimitri screeches, doing dramatic mid-air somersaults.
"I DON'T WANNA! NOT ANOTHER DISGRACED—"

“I’m still right here,” I mutter, eyebrow twitching.

“AND AN ILUYTRI?!”
He clutches his little head like he’s just witnessed the collapse of the cosmos.
“AND NOT JUST AN ILUYTRI BUT—**THAT ONE**??”

He wails like a child denied his juice box.
Full-on breakdown.
Tiny leafy cloak flapping with every dramatic breath.

“WAS THE DETENTION A TRIAL? AM I BEING TESTED? WHAT DID I DO—”

Okay.
What the heck have people been saying about me?

…

Oh.
Right.

Me.

Phoibus, clearly done with the theatrics, reached out and—without hesitation—grabbed Dimitri by the ankles.

Yes.
The ankles.

The little Kaabaig dangled upside down, cloak fluttering like a distressed leaf in autumn wind.

“Ms. Daphni,” Phoibus said with dangerous calm, “is a new trainee.
And the Third Prince’s assistant.”

His free hand glowed gold—bright, sunlit, steady.

“I expect you to treat her as such.”

Dimitri shrank visibly.
Literally.
I think he actually lost half an inch in height.

He nodded so furiously I feared for the structural integrity of his neck.

Then, with a princely smile—as if he hadn’t just reenacted an ancient punishment technique—Phoibus righted the pixie, adjusted his collar, and gently plopped his tiny hat back on.

“Seems the detention worked.”
He looked... satisfied.

Turning to me, his eyes softened—still gold, but dimmed like dusk.

“I still have work to do,” he said, voice warm. “Our session will continue tomorrow, my dear apprentice.”

He dipped his head, hand resting over his chest—a bow only a royal gives to those they respect.

“May the Threads of Fate never stop weaving.”

I blinked, caught somewhere between exasperation and awe.

“May you receive blessings and healing,” I said smoothly, offering a curtsy.

Dimitri whimpered softly from atop a shelf, clutching his hat like a traumatized war veteran.

Honestly? Same.

I Nearly Made Kaabaig Smore

Now here I am: Daphni of Iluyto, Daughter of Nobody, locked in a one-sided staring contest with a Kaabaig who is—may I emphasize—still perched on the highest shelf like a judgmental gargoyle.

He’s looking at me like I’ve committed a war crime.

(Which, to be fair, is probably what the gossip says.)

"Nice to meet you...?" I offer voice light. Hopeful.

He doesn’t blink.

He doesn’t move.

"No."

…

I blink.

No?

What in the Threads does that mean?

"I heard about you," Minnie McTantrum scoffs, his wings—which look suspiciously like a mosquito’s, mind you—buzzing furiously as he floats around like a very judgmental autumn leaf.
"Daphni. The reason the Third Prince is called the 'Fallen Spinner.'"

My eyebrow twitches.

Because of course he says that with the gravity of a priest delivering a curse—
Only to follow it up with a dramatic tantrum.

A high-pitched wail.
The clatter of tiny bells.
A blur of Kaian curses rattled off with theatrical precision.

And then he starts glowing—red and violet, sparks flickering like he's on the verge of combusting into ornamental fireworks.

As for me?

I would've singed his wings off for the dramatics— if he weren't floating just out of reach.

Deliberately, I might add.

I should probably stop him before he ruins the curtains or sets off the indoor vines.
They're twitching already. Preparing for what looks suspiciously like an uprising.

It's becoming a problem.

"Okay," I say, holding up my hands. "Maybe you should stop with the dramatics—"

"WAAAAHHHH! WHY IS IT YOU?!" he shrieks.

That was his actual response.

I am this close to committing arson in Fatum and earning a place in the history books as the first war criminal brought down by a pixie.

"I'm not that **bad**," I argue.

"**YOU ARE THAT BAD!!**"

...Okay. Fair.

“Listen. Yes, I’m the reason your beloved—”

“WAAAHH, POOR PRINCE PHOIBUS!”
The little creature full-on sobs into his own arms, shaking like grief itself.

“Okay, now you’re just overdoing it.”

There was clearly no use reasoning with this specific Kaabaig.

So I did the next best thing.

I burned the vines.

Because if there’s one thing that hurts a nature lover more than words—
it’s watching their precious plants curl into ash.

With my gloves now resting on the wooden desk, I let the warmth seep into my palms—
and guided it straight toward the overgrown vines.

I could set the entire curtain ablaze, just to make a point. I don’t. But the warmth is there—trembling at the edge of my knuckles.

The moment a flicker of smoke rose, sharp and curling—
and the scent of singed green hit the air—

Dimitri’s wails snapped into a shriek.

"WHAT ARE YOU DOING, YOU ILUYTRI?!?!?"

He shot down like a lightning strike,
a blur of wings and fury, trailing Kaia dust like wildfire.

With a frantic spin of his tiny hands and an unnecessary amount of sparkle,
the vines were instantly healed—lush, whole, untouched.

And just like that—the perfect height for some Kaabaig hunting.

With one swift motion, Dimitri was in my grasp.

Dangling. Defenseless. At my mercy.

"Now that we see each other eye-to-eye," I said sweetly, watching his Adam's apple bob like a trapped bird—
which, frankly, made me smile.

Politely, of course.

(The kind of polite that's really just a smirk in a pretty dress.)

"Shall we proceed with that long-overdue orientation?"
I tilted my head, voice sugar-sweet.
"Or should I prepare an Iluytri delicacy instead? Kaabaig S'more, perhaps?"

"THAT'S NOT REAL!"

"Oh?" I blinked, all innocence.
"And who's the Iluytri here?"

Poor guy was shivering like a leaf caught in a storm.
He was turning purple—violently so—like he was about to become the newest species of poisonous flora out of sheer spite.

The only communication exchanged was a series of microexpressions: a twitch of the jaw, a narrowing of eyes, a tilt of the head. Blue met copper. Copper met blue.

Blue blinked first. Copper let go.

That's right. Fear the future war criminal of Fatum, you pollen-sized menace.

""Minnie Dimitri, at your service," he grumbles.

His voice is surprisingly husky—and croaky, I note, probably from all the screeching earlier.
"...You're not gonna make me... a—"

"Kaabaig S'more?"

"Don't say it!"
He slaps his tiny hands over his pointed ears, voice gurgled and squeaky.
"...Is that really real?"

I manage to keep a straight face.
(It's not. No one eats a Kaabaig. Unless you want nature itself to hunt you down like a mother hen defending her chicks.)

"Depends," I say coolly, "on whether you're giving me that orientation."

"Gah! Fine!"
He throws his arms up like I just declared war. His wings flutter—fast, nervous, hummingbird-fast.
"...Why do you even need an orientation? You already know how this place works."

A good question.
This Kaabaig is smart, after all—beneath the theatrics and temper tantrums.

"The Sartyx is very keen on its rules and protocols," I say instead.

The bed creaks softly as I sit.
The fabric brushes against my bare hand—infuriatingly familiar.
Like touching a memory I didn't ask to remember.

"...You didn't listen during your detention, huh?"

The Kaabaig crosses his arms with a dramatic little "Hmph!"

"…Maybe."

He didn't.

Of course he didn't.

Not only did I have to become the Fallen Spinner's apprentice,
I also inherited a Kaabaig who seems to hate me—
with ears so enormous, you'd think he'd at least know the basic rules for Kaabaigs in the Sartyx.

But no.

The one who was exiled has to be the one doing the orientation.

"The Sartyx really lets anyone in nowadays, huh."

That did it.

He started glowing—actually glowing—red as fury, his tiny feet stomping the air like he was trying to summon a thunderstorm.

"I COULD SAY THE SAME ABOUT YOU!"
His finger jabbed the air like a dagger.
"WHY ARE YOU EVEN HERE? TO FRAY THREADS AGAIN? TO DESTROY FATES?"

Each word hit like a thread snapping in my chest.
Sharp. Familiar.

But I just smiled. Inhaled. Lifted my hand—
still missing a glove.

"I see you're turning quite red," I said calmly, voice velvet over steel.
"And I'm feeling rather famished."

The little guy practically shot toward the ceiling.
I genuinely thought he was going to hit it.

(Unfortunately, he didn't. Must've passed his flight exams after all.)

"I was kidding—!"

He clung to the ceiling fan like a startled bat, his cloak flapping pitifully.

Perfect.

I tilted my head, already reaching for the wall switch.

"You know how Kaabaigs are!" he squeaked. "One emotion at a time!"

"What emotion would you feel," I said sweetly, "if I turned on the ceiling fan right now?"

"You wouldn't."

"I absolutely would."

A pause.
Another round of blue meeting copper.

He sighed.

Victory.

"Welcome—uh… newcomer—"

"Daphni."

"Right. Daphni."
I swear I could hear both vitriol and a hint of fear in his voice.

"Welcome to Fatum's Sartyx."

"More feeling," I said. "From the top."

He paused. His little eyebrow twitched.

Satisfying.

“Welcome to Fatum’s Sartyx!”
He threw his arms out like a disgruntled stage actor delivering lines at swordpoint.

The enthusiasm was so bland it could curdle milk.

“I feel so welcome.”

“Moving on.” he muttered, "before I get roasted like marshmallow.

Dimitri Isn't A Good Tour Guide

My hair was a mess by the end of the tour.

My golden laurel wreath was crooked. My alampay? Crinkled—despite me specifically ironing it out with Warmth that morning.

Honestly, I looked like I'd gone twelve rounds with a particularly snappy Shear—which I do not wish upon anyone.

Dimitri, bless his pollen-sized soul, made it a habit of yanking my fringe whenever I lagged behind even a step.

He earned a slightly singed hat for that. (Victory. Sweet, smoky victory.)

But the Kaabaig didn't stop his tour at the Sartyx. No.

He puffed out his leafy little chest and declared—and I quote— "I AM A GOOD TOUR GUIDE! I CAN EVEN TOUR YOU THE WHOLE FATUM!"

All because I insulted his orientation skills.

And because I have poor self-preservation instincts, I dared him.

Which brings us here.

An Iluytri and a grudge-bearing Kaabaig, standing at the edge of what Fatum reverently calls:

Laywakilab.

The Forest of No Return.

Where fate goes to unravel.

Monsters that threaten the threads of destiny tend to linger here—drawn by frayed strands, discarded threads, broken stories too damaged to mend.

Spinners of the Sartryx toss them here. What cannot be saved… is cast out.

These creatures feed on what remains.

Sometimes, they leave the forest.

Sometimes, they cross the boundary—like the Shear.

I remember blade-like teeth. Claws that cut through metal like parchment.

Most who encounter them… don't walk away.

Which brings us to the current situation:

Me—standing at the entrance of a death-infested, fate-devouring forest.

And Minnie Dimitri—tipping his still-slightly-singed leafy hat like he's a gentleman at a ball and I'm the poor lady being asked for a waltz.

A pin. I need a pin.

"Now I really think," I said slowly, through gritted teeth, "that you didn't even listen to the orientation you were supposed to orient me about."

The glare I sent him should've ignited his hat on the spot. It would have, too—if we weren't standing on the first cursed blade of grass marking the border of Laywakilab.

Yes. That's right.

Because when I dared fall a few steps behind—with self-preservation in mind, mind you—Minnie Dimitri apparently took offense.

“She isn’t taking my tour seriously!” he must’ve thought.

And what did the little menace do?

He yanked a strand of my hair.

My precious, straightened, expertly styled hair.

And in doing so, dragged me across the edge of the drawn boundary of Preastres.

Oh, and in case you’re wondering—

Yes.

There’s a reason it’s called the Forest of No Return.

Because once you cross the boundary?

THERE IS LITERALLY NO RETURN.

Capital letters. Enchanted border. Fate-sealed law.

A safety precaution decreed by the kingdom of Clothos to keep aggressive monsters from spilling into civilized space. And more importantly—

A very clear, very glowing, very *do not step here* warning.

To stay. Far. Away.

Yet here we are.

Because of a pixie with a grudge and no regard for hair etiquette.

"How was I supposed to know!?" Dimitri shrieked, zipping through the air like a bloodthirsty mosquito. His voice cracked with panic. "I can't exactly see the boundary from up here!"

"Maybe if you looked down once in a while, you would've seen it," I hissed—low, sharp, not daring to raise my voice. "And maybe if you weren't busy rambling like some pretentious forest gremlin, we wouldn't be in this situation!"

"NOW YOU'RE BLAMING ME!?"

"WHO ELSE PULLED MY HAI—"

Snip.

Oh no.

I know that sound.

Snip. Snip.

Before Dimitri could even retort, I grabbed him out of the air and yanked him close to my chest.

Snip.

The sound echoed—closer now. Rhythmic. Precise.

I moved quickly, slipping into the thick underbrush, where the shadows deepened and the vines whispered too softly to be understood.

"Hey—" Dimitri's voice cracked into a whisper as he peeked out of my fingers, his usual whine cut short.

He saw my face.

He froze.

"...Why do you look so serious?"

I didn't respond, only gave him a look—which thankfully seemed to work because he didn't even made a single sound.

Right across from us stood a monster.

A thread-fraying monster.

Its silhouette was jagged—wrong. Like it had been cut from the world with trembling scissors.

Blade-edged teeth glinted beneath slack lips, twitching with anticipation. Its claws gleamed—needle-sharp and hungry.

And from the hollow sockets where eyes should’ve been, oozed that same gnarly, ink-dark liquid. Thick. Slow. Reeking of iron and rot.

The air itself went still.

No wind. No Kaabaig chatter. No Threads whispering.

Only breath. And that... thing.

A Shear.

A fate-hungry Shear.

The kind of monster that doesn’t kill you—not in the traditional sense.

No.

It cuts your thread.

And when it does?

You just don’t die.

You unravel.

"...Is that?" Dimitri whispered, his voice barely a breeze against my palm.

He pressed himself deeper into my hand, his usual glow dimming to a dull, frightened ember.

I didn’t speak.

I only nodded.

“We—” he gulped, his hands clutching his hat like it was the last thread holding him together. “We should... we should leave—!”

But before I could answer, the monster’s ears twitched.

A single chirp echoed from a tree above.

The Shear’s head snapped upward.

Then it roared.

Not a sound made for ears. No. It was made for threads—to slice, to sever, to end.

Black ichor splattered outward, hitting nearby leaves like a butcher’s blade.

I moved fast.

Covered Dimitri’s mouth before a squeak could escape.

Thankfully, he didn’t resist.

His tiny frame trembled against my fingers, his breath shallow, fast.

And me?

I felt the Warmth.

Rising.

Like fire pressed beneath my skin, curling in my lungs, seeking release.

Not now.

I pressed it down.

Swallowed it like a scream.

Held it there.

Controlled.

Placing Dimitri carefully on my shoulder, I gestured for silence with a single finger and began to crawl—slow, deliberate, every movement measured like a whisper.

I kept low to the ground, avoiding dried leaves and brittle twigs like they were traps—because in a way, they were.

And then—

Plop.

A fruit dropped nearby.

A pathetic, deadly sound.

I didn’t breathe.

In one motion, I ducked behind a hollow in the tree's bark, pressing myself tight into the curve of it. Warmth surged in my palms, scraping against my gloves like a caged scream.

The Shear moved.

Fast.

On all fours, it charged toward the fallen fruit. Its head twitched unnaturally, cracking at odd angles, neck rotating too far as it sniffed the air.

Another gurgling yowl echoed across the trees.

Dimitri covered his ears, shaking. His glow pulsed faintly—and a tiny gasp slipped from him.

I nearly threw him into the tree.

Because the second that sound escaped—

The Shear's head snapped toward us.

Empty eye sockets oozed dark, metallic sludge that sizzled on the forest floor. The smell of it—iron, rot, and old blood—curled into my nose and nearly made me gag.

Then—

It stepped forward.

Right up to the hole.

Its head dipped low. Too low.

And it started to enter.

I pressed my back harder into the wood, trying to melt into it, every inch of my body coiled and still.

Dimitri covered his mouth, trembling, his small form buried into the crook of my neck like a leaf trying to hide from fire.

The Shear's movements creaked like broken clockwork. Each twist and shudder sounded like something splintering.

The goo dripped. Splattered.

Closer.

Closer—

Chirp.

A bird sang.

Clear. Loud. Startling.

The Shear’s head twisted violently toward the sound.

Then it bolted—disappearing into the underbrush, galloping into the distance in jagged, unnatural strides.

Only then did I exhale.

Quiet.

Slow.

Measured.

Dimitri follows with a whisper of his own.

“...Is it gone?”
His voice wavers, each word fumbled and frayed at the edges.

“I... think so.” I reply, just as quietly.

“Th-then,” he gulps, wings twitching, “w-we should leave.”

Right. Because escaping a forest named No Return is definitely that simple.

I bite back the snark, swallowing it like I do the warmth rising in my chest.

“...We could try.”

As quiet as a mouse, I crawled out, limbs aching, senses sharp. Dimitri fluttered just behind me, his wings trembling more than flapping.

The black sludge clung to my arms, sticky and cold. I swallowed down the nausea curling at the back of my throat.

"Ho—"

Snip.

The sound froze me.

And then—

A blur.

Red claws.

A shriek.

The Shear—the same Shear, the one we thought had vanished—lunged from the shadows.

Its jagged claws snatched Dimitri mid-air, wrapping around his wings like a vice.

I gasped, choking it back as the creature crouched before me—eye sockets oozing, grin stretching far too wide.

It brought him closer to its dripping, ink-stained nose, like it was inhaling the scent of fear.

"NO—NO!" Dimitri thrashed wildly, black ichor staining his leaf-cloak. "HELP ME—HELP ME!"

Warmth seeps into my veins.

It begs to be let out.

The world slows—no, stops. The wind vanishes. Even time holds its breath.

The grass beneath me feels like knives—digging into my skin like tiny hands, pleading. Grasping. Begging for something I don't have.

I…

I don't know what to do.

I'm not a hero. Not a warrior.

I'm just a disgraced girl from Iluyto.

An Iluytri who frayed her own thread.

Just like a Shear.

Warmth pulses—hot, then hotter.

The forest stares.

It watches. Listens. Waits.

For a murder? A scream? A sacrifice?

No.

A funeral. Maybe for both of us.

Warmth surges.

And then—before thought can stop me—my hand moves.

It meets the Shear's face.

A flash of light.

A gurgled sound of 'Thank You'

And in its place—

A new thread.

Delicate. Glowing. Whole.

What?

My touch unravels. It never creates. And yet—here it is. Something new.

Dimitri lay on the ground.

Still.

Eyes wide, dilated—fixed on me with something between fear and awe. Or maybe confusion. Or... trauma?

I don't know.

“W—” he croaked.

Then his gaze shifted.

To the thread.

The new thread. Glowing faintly where the Shear used to be.

“...Did you—”

“I don’t know!” I finally burst, hands flying up in sheer panic.

“YOU ROASTED A SHEAR!”

“I DIDN’T MEAN TO!”

“WHAT DO YOU MEAN—?!”

“IT JUST—HAPPENED!”

There was a beat of silence.

Then, Dimitri—still trembling—slowly stood up.

Took one cautious step.

Then another.

And then he ran.

Ran straight toward me, with those tiny Kaabaig legs pumping like he was charging into war.

And then—

He hugged me.

(Okay. He latched onto my knees. But the sentiment was there.)

“WAAAAHHH!!!”

The wail shattered the silence like a dropped plate.

Dimitri latched onto my skirt, sobbing so hard his tiny body trembled against the fabric.

“YOU SAVED ME!” he howled, voice hoarse and cracked, like it hurt him to shout but he couldn’t stop.

I blinked.

Once.

Twice.

I… what?

His hands were fisting the cloth like it was the only thing keeping him together.

"I THOUGHT I WAS GONNA D—D—" His voice fractured again, splintering on the word like it was too sharp to say. "WAAAAHHH!"

He sobbed against my skirt, full body trembling, tears and snot clinging like ivy to silk.

I stared down, mildly horrified.

I patted his head. Once. Awkwardly.

"...Please don’t wipe your snot on my skirt."

He sniffled louder.

I sighed, scooping him gently into my palm, his leafy cloak still crumpled with panic.

Then I paused. The breath caught in my chest and refused to move—

“Wait—”

My gaze dropped.

“Your wings.”

Dimitri froze.

A Kaabaig without wings.... A Kaabaig who couldn't fly...

I knew what that meant. And I hated that I knew.

His wings drooped behind him, twitching slightly, like it wanted to fly but had already given up.

One of them—torn. Split down the middle like a frayed thread.

“…Yeah,” he said quietly, eyes not meeting mine.

Oh no.

A Kaabaig with a broken wing… means they’re crippled.

And crippled means worthless.

In Kaabaig culture, that word isn’t thrown lightly. It’s a verdict.

I shake my head, throat tight, unable to argue.

"I—" I gulped, unable to gave the strength of look at his wings, "I'm so sorry."

I wanted to stitch him whole again. But—my hands only frayed.

Never repairs.
Only **burns**.

"Don't." He places a hand on my cheek, "It's not your fault."

"It's mine." He smiled as he said it. A small, broken smile.
As if saying it first could make it hurt less.

Then—

A guttural snarl.

From behind us.

Another Shear.

My body moves before thought does.

Without hesitation, I scoop him up, cradle him to my shoulder—

And run.

Deeper into the forest.

Where fate unravels.

Where monsters follow.

Where no one is meant to return.

Nature closes in.

Dimitri’s tiny hands glow green, trembling—but sure.

With every step I take, vines surge from the soil, shrubs twist upward, and thorns curl like protective claws. The forest listens to him—answers him.

“I’ll close our path!” Dimitri shouts, voice cracking with both fear and focus. “Just keep running!”

“Easier said than done!” I bark back, leaping over a root, ducking under a branch, nearly tripping over a rock that seemed to rise just to spite me.

Behind us—

Snip. Snap. Tear.

The sound of leaves being shredded. Branches falling like paper. Threads of nature sliced clean by something with no right to exist.

A Shear was still chasing.

And it was getting closer.

“No!”

A rock caught my foot, sending me and Dimitri tumbling.

He flew—tiny body flung like a ragdoll—into the thorns.

Pain shot through me as claws sank into my torso, sharp and deliberate. I was lifted, held aloft like prey.

The Shear did not see.

It only felt.

It only smelled.

Its slack mouth opened, threads of ichor stretching.

“STAY AWAY—!” Dimitri’s voice cracked like thunder.

A branch snapped from above and slammed against the creature’s skull.

But it barely flinched.

The Shear roared.

And that’s when Warmth surged again.

Not flickering. Not trembling.

Roaring.

Unflappable. Uncontainable.

The world narrowed. Dimitri’s cries became white noise. Even the pain dulled.

All I could feel was—

Warmth.

Not heat. Not fire.

Warmth.

The gloves—still pristine, still impossibly intact—glowed iridescent. Threads of gold and pearl shimmered across my skin as Warmth overtook both me and the Shear.

And for a second—

Just a second—

It looked relieved.

Its claws loosened. Its limbs trembled.

I gripped its hand tighter.

Let the Warmth burn.

“…ah… mama… warm…”

My brows drew together.

Did it just—?

Before I could answer that question, nature intervened.

Vines surged upward. Tree branches curled around the Shear like mourning arms.

And this time—

It didn’t resist.

It let itself be overtaken.

Dimitri didn’t let go of my skirt.

Not even when the Shear—overtaken by vines and silence—unraveled into a single thread.

Just like the previous one.

Then came the sound of hooves and blades—footsteps scattering the underbrush. Armor clinking. Horses neighing.

“Daphni!”

Phoibus.

He leapt from his horse, falling to his knees in front of me. His hands—steady, warm—cupped my face. His thumbs brushed the dirt and blood from my cheek.

“I felt someone step beyond Preastres—”

He looked down.

A sharp inhale. His eyes flared gold.

“You’re bleeding.”

His voice broke on the word.

Then: “Dimitri.”

The Kaabaig flinched.

“I excused your rude behavior earlier. But you—you let the Second-Aide of the Third Prince enter Laywakilab unguarded!?”

For all his dramatics and fire, Dimitri only bowed his head. Wings trembling. Silent.

I reached out—gently scooping him back into my hand, curling my fingers protectively around him.

“This isn’t the time,” I whispered. My voice rough, broken.

“He’s… injured too.”

Phoibus looked at me then.

Really looked.

And for a moment, the royal mask cracked—revealing a raw ache behind his golden eyes.

“…I’ll carry you, okay?” he murmured, already sliding one hand beneath my knees, the other supporting my back. “Just… stay awake.”

"Please."

Easier said than done.

Because the moment he said it—

I blacked out.

Objection! The Menace Stays

After suffering through a three-hour lecture from none other than Phoibus, I lay buried in the Sartryx infirmary bed.

My gloves were still intact—a blessing in itself, considering I had just burned through two monsters. They no longer glowed, though; the iridescence had faded, leaving only the dull shimmer of Warmth sleeping beneath.

Two pillows, a weighted white blanket (Phoibus' orders, of course)—I was practically drowned in enforced comfort.

Yet my mind refused to rest.

All I could think about was the strangeness—the impossible thing I'd witnessed—

Shears unraveling into Threads.

That concept baffled me.

It was a well-known truth in Fatum: Shears existed for one purpose and one purpose alone—
To destroy destiny.

They were destruction made flesh.
Chaos incarnate.
Threadless, tetherless, bound to nothing.

And me?

I was Iluytri.
Warmth burns. It consumes.
It doesn't create.

Yet.

Beneath all that lush nature and dread—
Two monsters unraveled.
Became mere Threads at my touch.

As if they had been... freed.
As if being burned by an Iluytri's Warmth was mercy.

Warmth surged again.
Tingling. Trembling. Alive.

No.

I inhaled it back in—forced it down.

Iluytri Warmth only destroys.
It frays.

It never—

Never creates.

But—

But the memory lingered.
Threads wrapping around my Warmth-filled hands.

Whole.
Shining.
Singing like something born.

"Ah, my dear apprentice," Phoibus said, setting a cup of chamomile tea onto the cupboard with maddening regal grace,
"Did the nurse not tell you to lie down?

Or shall I do the honors?"

I furrowed my eyebrows, scrunching my nose.

"If the nurses in the Sartyx treated patients with something other than gossip and stink-eyes, the patient might actually listen."

"Ah."

Phoibus' eyes gleamed — just for a moment — before he sank smoothly into the empty chair next to my bed.

Oh no.

Small talk.

Someone get a Shear. I'd rather wrestle another one again.

"... As you know," he begins, his hands perfectly positioned on his lap—posture straight and fit for a prince ready to deliver some royal decree,
"Apprentices crossing the border of Preastres—or worse, stepping foot into Laywakilab—is a punishable offense."

Tell me something I don't know.

But since I'm polite, I only offer a nod.

"But," Phoibus continues, his eyes flashing gold for a heartbeat,
"Knowing you—you wouldn't go there without reason.
You wouldn't."

(Who would even want to go there willingly?)

"And," he adds, voice tipping warmer,
"Minnie Dimitri—your assigned Kaabaig—testified in your defense.

He acknowledged that he... led you there."

What.

"Hang on—"

"He is willing to step down as a Kaabaig of the Sartyx as punishment—"

"That's basically exile!" I blurt.

"And I agree with his decision," Phoibus interjects smoothly, raising a hand to cut me off.

"Minnie Dimitri has grown in a short span of time.
But putting the Second-Aide of the Third Prince in danger is punishable in itself."

My gaze dropped.

I couldn't find fault in it.

Dimitri broke one of the Sartyx's oldest rules:
Protect your assigned person.

Still—

A sudden flash—
Broken wings. Screams for help.

My Warmth burst outward, my hands flaring with a fiery edge.

Gloves glowing iridescent once more.

Phoibus' voice cut through the haze—steady, commanding.

"Control it, Daphni."

As if control could stop my hands from remembering.

I inhaled once more.
Forceful. Pleading.

The Warmth in my hands slowly subsided.
A faint shimmer of periwinkle returned—soft, steady—and the heat inside me settled into something almost bearable.

"Good girl," Phoibus murmured, offering the chamomile tea again.

"Here."

"I don't need—"

"You need it," he said simply.

I accepted it.

His fingers brushed mine—steady, warm, deliberate.

Like he was weaving something invisible.

A thread.
A promise.

"...Wings," I start.

"Hm?" Phoibus hums, his eyes meeting mine—
Intense. Gilded. Gold.

"His wings. They're... broken."

I look away, unable to hold the weight of his gaze.

"I was too late," I whisper.

"Because of me, he—"

Became a disgrace.

Not... important.

"I was too slow," I decide, the words tasting like ash in my mouth.

Slow.

And now, fiery little Minnie Dimitri—
Rendered useless.

Beneath.

Like me.

An Iluytri.

Broken by birthright.
Expected to fail.

Warm hands held my face gently,
As if I were fragile glass—
Not broken shards.

Phoibus, slow as an hour, lifted my head.

His mouth was tight.
His brows furrowed.

Pity?
Shame?

I wrenched his hands off mine.

"Don't look at me like that."

"Like what?"

"Like I'm—"
I faltered.
Looked away.

"Nevermind."

He said nothing.

He simply stayed.

And, eventually—

I stayed, too.

I could hear the crinkling of his robes.
The soft creak of the chair.
The faint chime of Clothos jewelry—the sunray crown he never bothered to remove.

He was Sun itself.

Big.
Bright.
Golden.

And—

Warm.

Never scorching.
Never—

Never burning.

"Phani—"

He caught himself.
Swallowed the familiar name back into his lungs.

"Daphni," he corrected quietly.

"Regarding your Kaabaig—"
He exhaled, steady but strained.

"The new one will arrive soon."

I froze.

"Minnie Dimitri is now considered... useless in the eyes of the Sartyx."

His voice tightened, almost imperceptibly, around the word useless.

"Due to his negligence," he continued, colder now, "he is designated an outsider. He will be given three days to prepare his leave to Kaia."

"No. I refuse—"

"You cannot refuse Sartryx's law."

"But that's what you do—"

"I cannot change this," he snapped, voice low and furious.

His eyes blazed—golden, unyielding, furious.

"Minnie Dimitri's assignment to you was his final chance to prove himself."

He exhaled through his nose—sharp. Pained.

"He failed."

His voice cracked once.

"That’s it."

Warmth surged again.
Again.

Like wildfire and untamed ichor beneath my skin.

I tried to hold it in.
But Warmth—stubborn, relentless—only grew.

"No. It's my Kaabaig. My choice."

My voice cracked.
Warmth slithered—slow and alive—through my veins.

"Dimitri—this isn't fair to him!"

"The law has been fair," Phoibus said, voice hard.
"Fair to judge that he put the Third Prince’s Second-Aide in danger.
Fair to witness his broken wings—"

"No. You don't understand!"

"What do I not understand, Daphni?"

His voice was quiet.
But his eyes—

They burned.

"He—he wasn't useless!"

"If he wasn't," Phoibus said slowly, deadly, "then why were you there?
Why were you hurt?"

I opened my mouth—

And nothing came out.

"That—"

"Minnie Dimitri didn't just endanger you."
Phoibus' voice cut through the room like a blade.
"He endangered both of you. He led you beyond Preastres.
And you were hurt."

I clenched my fists.
The truth.

I could not refute it.

"But he isn't useless—"

"Let the other Kaabaigs judge his broken wings," Phoibus said, his voice so cold it burned.
"And we'll see."

It's my fault.

My fault again.
Another—another person dragged down by me.

Daughter of Nobody.
Fallen Spinner.
The Third Prince's Reason for Disgrace.
Harbinger of Chaos.

Warmth surged—wild, desperate—turning my periwinkle gloves iridescent.

Barely holding it in.

Everything blurred.
Muffled.

Static—

Never clear.

"Phani—!"

A voice—

Someone?

"Phani—"

Light bled into my vision.

Gold.
Radiant.

Safe.

I reached for it—

Until a sharp wince snapped the world back into focus.

Phoibus staggered back—

His hands were red, blistered, burning.

My Warmth.

I gasped—

Called it back, forced it inward—
Swallowed it down before it could do more.

"Your Highness—"

"Shh..."

He reached out again, flinching when his burned fingers brushed my clothed hands.

"Breathe in. Breathe out."

I shook my head, chest tight, vision blurred.

"I'm—I'm so sorry," I choked out, letting him hold my palm anyway, listening to the soft mantra he offered.

"I didn't mean to—"

"I know," he whispered.
"It's okay."

No.

No, it's not.

His hands were blistered and burning—because of me.

"Daphni," he said softly, almost pleading.
"Was I too cold? I didn't mean to hurt you."

I couldn't answer.

I could only stare at his injured hands, my own trembling with helpless, useless Warmth.

I tried to pry my hands away—slowly, carefully—not wanting to burn him further.

But Phoibus didn’t let go.

Instead, he tightened his grip, blistered hands curling around mine like he was anchoring himself too.

"Your Highness, please—" I whispered, guilt gnawing at my chest.

"Look at me," he said.

I obeyed.

His golden eyes were steady. Unwavering.
And in them, not pity. Not judgment.

Only something dangerously close to faith.

"...Minnie Dimitri—" Phoibus swallowed, voice rasping like spun thread fraying at the edges.
"If you truly want him to stay... I can help you."

I blinked.

"What?" I breathed.

He smiled—a small, tired thing.
A crack of light in a crumbling world.

"Trust me," he said.

I stiffened.

I didn't like the sound of that.

But between the Sartryx, the law, the inevitability of losing something again—

I had no choice.

"...Why?" I asked, voice breaking softer than a snapped thread.

Phoibus’ smile faltered—just for a heartbeat.

Then he leaned in, voice dropping low enough that only I could hear:

"Beyond the Sartryx," he whispered, "he is my friend, too.”